

and developers can target Windows Phone, Windows and Zune HD for free. XNA makes things easier on developers by providing a single development environment. So they can easily reuse code, even entire game engines, between the platforms, or even port the same games between the supported platforms.

- ▶ **Xbox Live:** Microsoft's amazing online game service for the Xbox 360 provides a wide range of functionality for gamers, including (but not limited to) multi-player gaming with matchmaking, in-game achievements with gamer points, friends lists, in-game and extra-game communications capabilities, leaderboards and much more. It works with certain Windows-based games through the awkwardly named Games for Windows - LIVE, and now it works with Windows Phone as well.

Looking at games on Windows Phone, there are basically two types of games: those that are a part of Xbox Live and those that are not. And while it may be convenient to think of Xbox Live titles as being more professional, that's a bit of a stretch. We think of it more like this: Anyone can write a game for Windows Phone, and those games can be as sophisticated (or not) as the developer wishes. But those games that wish to take advantage of features like achievements and leaderboards will need to be part of Xbox Live. And to become a part of Microsoft's curated, tightly controlled online service, there are some hoops to jump through. Generally speaking, the world's biggest developers will be using Xbox Live features while individual developers won't. But that's just a generality.

Xbox Live is so important to the Windows Phone game experience that we'll now be taking a side trip to show you what's going on with this exciting online service. We'll have you take a look at which parts of Xbox Live are available on Windows Phone, and jump from there into the Games Hub, which is the central location for all of your gaming activities on the phone.

Xbox LIVE

Xbox Live began in 2002 as a feature of the original Xbox console. Back in the early days, it was essentially a vehicle for *Halo* and *Halo 2* multi-player gaming, and indeed many of the core features we now associate with Xbox Live came out of Microsoft's experiences with those early *Halo* games.

The modern Xbox Live service came to life in 2005 with the launch of the Xbox 360. (And if you're familiar with Games for Windows - LIVE, you know that this service essentially delivers an almost complete Xbox Live experience on Microsoft's dominant PC platform as well.) At this time,